

UPSC Civil Services (Main) — PHILOSOPHY (Optional) Paper I

Date: 2026-06-21 | Maximum Marks: 250 | Time: 3 Hours

Topics: History & Problems of Philosophy — Western (Sec. A) + Indian (Sec. B)

INSTRUCTIONS:

- There are EIGHT questions divided in TWO Sections — Section A (Western) and Section B (Indian).
- Candidate has to attempt FIVE questions in all.
- Question Nos. 1 and 5 are COMPULSORY; of the remaining, attempt THREE, choosing AT LEAST ONE from each Section.
- The number of marks carried by a question / part is indicated against it.
- Answers may be written either in English or in the medium authorized in the Admission Certificate.
- Word limits, wherever specified, should be adhered to. Keep answers analytical and illustrate with examples.
- Practice paper grounded in the official UPSC Philosophy syllabus; difficulty calibrated to CSM 2022-2025 PYQs.

SECTION A — WESTERN PHILOSOPHY (Questions 1-4)

Q.1 is compulsory. Attempt any TWO more from Q.2-Q.4 (remember: at least ONE question must also be taken from Section B).

Q1. Write short notes on **each** of the following in about 150 words each:

- (a) Plato's Theory of Forms as the bridge between epistemology and metaphysics. **(10)**
- (b) Descartes' method of doubt and the certainty of the *cogito*. **(10)**
- (c) Berkeley's dictum *esse est percipi* (to be is to be perceived). **(10)**
- (d) Kant's distinction between phenomena and noumena. **(10)**
- (e) The Logical Positivist critique of metaphysics. **(10)**

Q.1 is COMPULSORY · Section A · 5 x 10 = 50 marks

- Q2.**
- (a) Examine Aristotle's doctrine of the four causes and show how the distinction between potentiality and actuality explains change and becoming. **(20)**
 - (b) "By substance I understand that which is in itself and is conceived through itself." Discuss Spinoza's conception of substance and his monism in the light of this definition. **(15)**
 - (c) How does Leibniz's theory of monads and the doctrine of pre-established harmony seek to resolve the mind-body problem? **(15)**

Section A · 50 marks

- Q3.** (a) Critically analyse Hume's contention that the idea of necessary connection in causation arises merely from habit and the psychological association of ideas. **(20)**
- (b) What does Kant mean by synthetic *a priori* judgments, and why does he regard their possibility as the central problem of the *Critique of Pure Reason*? **(15)**
- (c) Examine Locke's distinction between primary and secondary qualities and Berkeley's objections to it. **(15)**

Section A · 50 marks

- Q4.** (a) Explain Russell's theory of definite descriptions and show how it dissolves the puzzle generated by the sentence "The present King of France is bald." **(20)**
- (b) Distinguish between pictorial form and logical form in Wittgenstein's picture theory of meaning, and explain the distinction between *saying* and *showing*. **(15)**
- (c) "Existence precedes essence." Discuss this Sartrean thesis and its implications for human freedom and responsibility. **(15)**

Section A · 50 marks

SECTION B — INDIAN PHILOSOPHY (Questions 5-8)

Q.5 is compulsory. Attempt the remaining question(s) needed to make FIVE in all, ensuring at least ONE is taken from Section A.

- Q5.** Write short notes on **each** of the following in about 150 words each:
- (a) The Carvaka rejection of inference (*anumana*) as a valid source of knowledge. **(10)**
- (b) The Jaina doctrine of *Saptabhanginaya* (sevenfold predication). **(10)**
- (c) The Buddhist doctrine of *Pratityasamutpada* (dependent origination). **(10)**
- (d) The Samkhya arguments for the existence of *Purusa*. **(10)**
- (e) *Cittavrtti-nirodha* in Patanjali's Yoga. **(10)**

Q.5 is COMPULSORY · Section B · 5 x 10 = 50 marks

- Q6.** (a) Examine the Nyaya-Vaisesika theory of causation (*asatkaryavada*) and contrast it with the Samkhya theory of *satkaryavada*. **(20)**
- (b) Present the Nyaya proofs for the existence of *Isvara* (God). **(15)**
- (c) Explain the Vaisesika theory of categories (*padarthas*). **(15)**

Section B · 50 marks

- Q7.** (a) "Brahman is both the efficient (*nimitta*) and the material (*upadana*) cause of the world." Discuss this Advaita position and the role of *Maya* in it. **(20)**
- (b) Examine Ramanuja's principal objections (*anupapatti*) against the Advaita doctrine of *Maya*. **(15)**
- (c) Discuss the Mimamsa doctrine of the intrinsic validity of knowledge (*svatah pramanya*). **(15)**

Section B · 50 marks

- Q8.** (a) Critically discuss the Buddhist doctrine of momentariness (*ksanikavada*) and its connection with the no-self theory (*nairatmyavada*). **(20)**
- (b) Explain Sri Aurobindo's conception of evolution and involution in his theory of Integral Yoga. **(15)**
- (c) Distinguish between bondage (*bandha*) and liberation (*moksa*) according to Jaina philosophy. **(15)**

Section B · 50 marks

— END OF QUESTION PAPER —

Total: 250 Marks | UPSC Practice Paper | Copilot CLI UPSC Agent